According to some, Don thought of himself as a kind of “deputy president” empowered to make important decisions involving the administration. Although I only found out about it later, he resisted having others see me alone and wouldn’t forward letters or documents to me unless he saw them first. In short, he wanted to be the *only* conduit to the Oval Office, in effect making that presidential isolation I just complained about even more complete. Nancy, ever protective of me, had been among the first to urge me to let Don go after the Iran-Contra affair began—although, as I’ve said, I didn’t believe he had done anything to warrant it. But the morale issue was another matter, and I decided to look into it, especially after new problems came up following my surgery in January.

My doctors told me to take it easy for up to six weeks after the operation. Nancy, always a doctor’s daughter, wanted me to follow their orders. After I left the hospital, she said she thought Don was pushing me too hard in scheduling public appearances, and at one point she called him about it. He ended the conversation by hanging up on her. That night, in early February, when I came up to the family quarters after work, she was very upset and told me how he had hung up on her. I was troubled by this kind of temperamental outburst, especially toward Nancy, who has always had only my best interests at heart.

By then, many other people in the administration were confirming what Nancy had told me about the morale problem and about Don’s efforts to shield me from virtually all opinions other than his own. Once it started, I heard the same thing over and over again: Don required everything to go through him. Just down the hall from the Oval Office, he was in a position to do that. I had always liked Don and enjoyed his Irish humor, but that wasn’t the way I wanted to run the store.